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Chicago Tribune



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SATURDAY, DECEMBER 20, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Chicago police Detective John Sullivan patrols at the CTA Red Line Roosevelt station on Friday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

White House threatens to withhold \$50M from CTA

Administration calls transit authority plan to add police ‘materially deficient’

By **Talia Soglin**
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Transit Authority’s plan to boost the number of police officers and K-9 guards on the city’s mass transit system is “materially deficient,” President Donald Trump’s administration said Friday as it threatened to cut the system off from up to \$50 million in federal funding.

Trump’s Federal Transit Administration threatened Dec. 8 to withhold federal funding from the CTA if it did not comply with the demands of a “special directive,” including by upping security on the city’s

buses and trains. In doing so, the administration invoked the apparently random attack against a 26-year-old woman who was doused with gasoline while riding a Blue Line train last month.

The FTA gave the CTA a tight timeline to comply with its special directive, telling it to submit a “security enhancement plan” within a week and implement it by Dec. 19.

The CTA announced Thursday it would boost security on the transit system starting Friday. The agency said it would increase the number of Chicago police officers in the “voluntary special employment program” on the transit system from an average of 77

per day to 120 per day. K-9 security staffing, for which the CTA contracts privately, will also increase from an average of 172 canine security guards per day to 188 per day.

But on Friday, Trump’s FTA said it wasn’t satisfied with the CTA’s plan.

In a letter to acting CTA President Nora Leerhsen, Federal Transit Administrator Marcus Molinaro said the plan “fails to meet the need for immediate, measurable corrective action to maintain a safe operating environment for workers and passengers.”

Turn to CTA, Page 2

Some Illinois hospitals won’t participate in aid-in-dying

Organizations opposed to law are allowed to opt out

By **Lisa Schencker**
Chicago Tribune

Though a new Illinois law allows doctors to help terminally ill people end their lives, several Illinois health systems with religious affiliations say they will not participate.

OSF HealthCare, Ascension and Hospital Sisters Health System all say they will not take part in medical aid-in-dying.

The new law, which sparked controversy and barely passed the Senate during the fall legislative session, specifically does not force health care professionals or health care organizations to help people end their lives.

In fact, the law allows health care organizations to prohibit health care professionals, staff, employees and independent contractors from practicing aid-in-dying



People participate in a candlelight vigil outside Gov. JB Pritzker’s office in Chicago on Dec. 11 to urge Pritzker to veto legislation that legalizes physician-assisted suicide in Illinois. Pritzker signed the legislation. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

care while performing duties for the organization.

“OSF HealthCare is saddened to hear that Governor Pritzker signed SB 1950 into law,” the system said in a statement. “As a Catholic health ministry, OSF is guided by honoring the dignity of every human person and we will not participate in or support any form of physician-assisted suicide. These practices are fundamentally inconsistent with our Mission to serve with the greatest care and love.”

OSF HealthCare has 16 hospitals in Illinois, including OSF HealthCare Little Company of Mary Medical Center in Evergreen Park.

Turn to Hospitals, Page 2

CHICAGO CITY BUDGET

Council OKs plan without head tax

Aldermen set up showdown as mayor mulls first veto of spending vote in decades

By **Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan**
Chicago Tribune

The budget counterproposal crafted by opponents of Mayor Brandon Johnson won a critical first full City Council vote Friday, setting up the mayor to soon concede their remarkable weeklong fight — or issue Chicago’s first mayoral veto of a budget in decades.

Aldermen voted 29-19 to approve the revenue piece of an alternative 2026 spending plan that does not include Johnson’s corporate head tax. That’s shy of the 34-vote threshold needed to override a potential mayoral veto, however, leaving the door open for the City Hall standoff to escalate further still. And with under two weeks until an end-of-year deadline to approve a budget, all factions agree Chicago is inching too close for comfort to a government shutdown.

When the moment came Friday, aldermen debated for mere moments before quickly passing the plan.

“The city of Chicago’s financial position is at a critical juncture,” said Ald. Pat Dowell, Johnson’s handpicked Finance chair who played a critical role in the effort that outmuscled him. “And I think we have emerged today with a budget plan that protects programs which are vital to those most in need while setting on the right path toward a stronger fiscal future.”

The \$16.6 billion aldermanic package contains a debt sale measure that Johnson has called Thursday “morally bankrupt” and his “red line.” His budget team warned such a novel proposal should not

Turn to Budget, Page 4

US strikes suspected IS sites in Syria

By **Eric Schmitt**
The New York Times

WASHINGTON — The United States began major airstrikes against the Islamic State group in Syria on Friday, fulfilling President Donald Trump’s vow to avenge the deaths of two Army soldiers and a civilian U.S. interpreter killed in a terrorist attack in the central part of the country last Saturday.

U.S. fighter jets, attack helicopters and artillery salvos struck dozens of suspected Islamic State sites at several locations across central Syria, including weapons storage areas and other buildings to support operations, according to a U.S. official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss operational matters.

The U.S. air and artillery attacks were expected to last several hours, deep into early Saturday morning in Syria, in what the U.S. official said would be “a massive attack.”

Social media accounts in Syria reported explosions across wide swaths of the country.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth sought to tamp down fears that the

Turn to Syria, Page 4

CPS data shows academic gains

While students show gains in reading and math, interim CEO Macqueline King said the “encouraging” data is just the start toward meeting the district’s long-term goals. **Chicagoland**

DOJ releases some Epstein files

The Justice Department released thousands of files from its investigation into Jeffrey Epstein, even as it acknowledged that its disclosure of the probe was incomplete. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 41 Low 15

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 354 © Chicago Tribune

